

Nopah and Kingston

May 21st & 22nd, 2011

Nopah Range High Point (6,394'), Kingston Peak (7,336')

Southeast of Death Valley near the NV border, CA

Full Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157626666408019/>

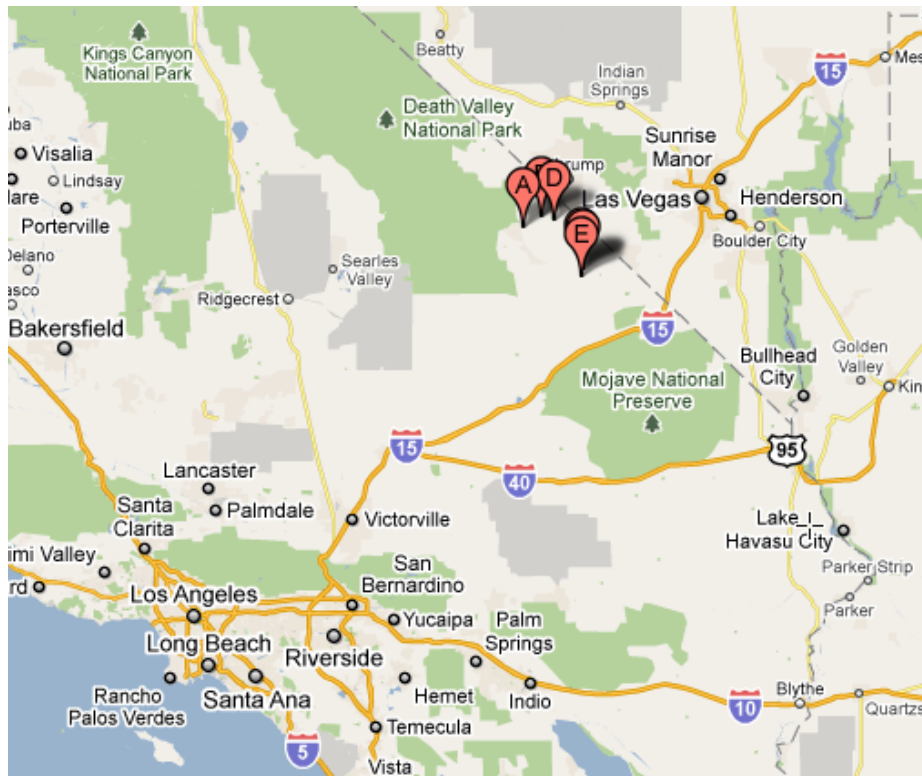
Everyone was all packed and ready for a snow climb. 21 or so people had signed up for Dan Richter and Asher Waxman's Excelsior and Dunderberg SPS trip and my carpool had already worked out logistics for the long drive up the east side past Mono Lake.

Then the spring weather turned again and we were looking at 20 inches of new snow. New snow that would be sitting unconsolidated on top of the existing hardpack which meant avalanche danger. And on top of that the forecast called for high winds and more precipitation.

So the call was made to reschedule that trip. Unfortunately my schedule meant I couldn't go on the new date but it did leave me with two whole days with nothing to do.



I quickly retreated into my trip planning headquarters (otherwise known as The Refuge Pub in Boise) and two Dead Guy's later I had a plan.



Nopah and Kingston were two peaks on the DPS list that could be easily paired in a weekend and I couldn't recall having seen them led recently. Nopah had an interesting looking 3rd class variation, the weather didn't look to bad, and the drive wasn't too long.

(Not too long translates to we made the trailhead sometime around 1 am.)

Jack Kieffer, Lisa Miyake, and Anne Kircher (a student from my WTC group this year who had so far only heard of my trips in song and legend) all made arrangements to head up after work Friday in Jack's truck.

We drove the 15 to Baker, then went north to Shoshone, and from there took the 178 north east until we exited the road and went down a series of faint dirt roads.



After turning off the 178 we had a little bit of difficulty following the DPS guide to find the trailhead at Twelvemile Spring. The area had been traversed in every direction by off roaders and it took a few passes before we found the right set of tracks. While doing this we came across Jason Stone and Laurent Hoffman (another WTC student of mine) who joined us in a caravan.

Eventually we saw headlamps out in the desert in front of us and soon found the last car with Neal Robbins and Dave Chapman.



That was everyone so we were all set.

After a brief excursion to the nearby spring where we found more mice than water everyone crawled into their bags for a few quick hours of sleep.

I cheerfully woke everyone a bit before dawn after at least 3 or 4 hours of sleep and they went about their morning rituals with slightly less than overwhelming enthusiasm.



Nopah was clearly visible in the distance. The summit is the high point of the range and is actually the slightly less pointed bump to the right.



The route was simple; 4 or so miles across the desert floor and aim for a big canyon. At that point we just had to be careful to follow the route lest we miss the fun 3rd class bit promised by the guide.



Along the way we happened across a section marker. This was interesting as it didn't correspond with the marker locations on our maps.



It was really starting to warm up as the sun came up over the mountains and it was a relief to make it into the canyon where it was still relatively cool.





As we climbed up a side canyon we could see a rather interesting feature in the rock behind us.





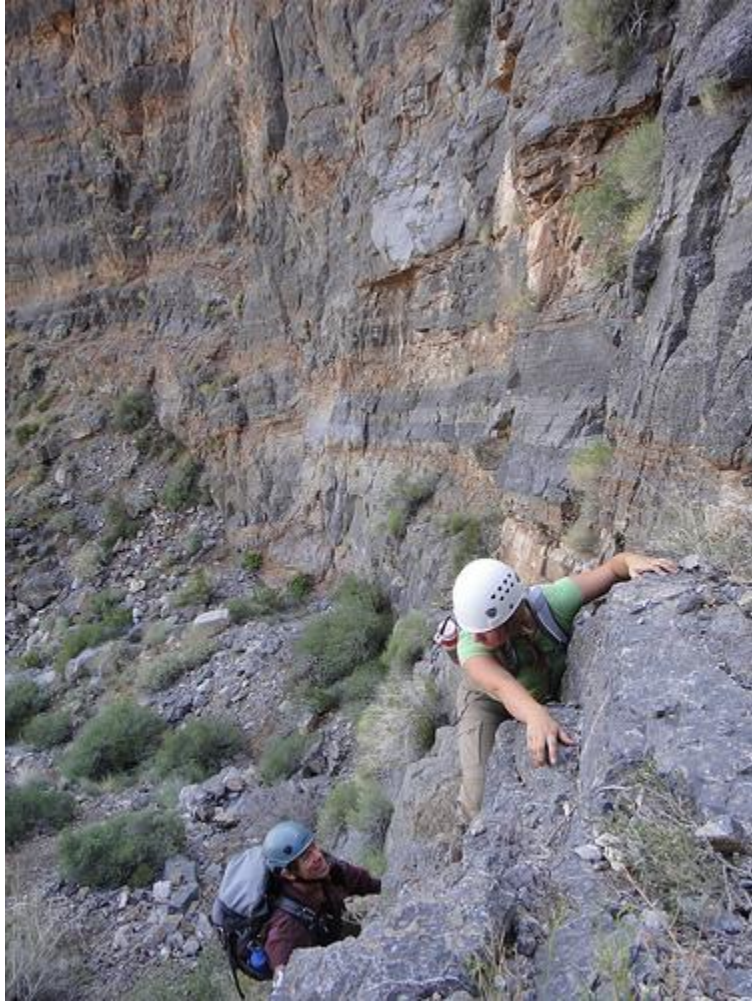
This is the 3rd class section described in the DPS guide. It's supposed to be an easy 3rd class waterfall followed by a high 3rd class section.



The first bit was no problem and everyone scrambled up quickly looking quite dashing in their helmets.



I'd expected something worse from the 2nd section based on a trip report from Bob Burd but it turned out to just be a bit loose.





Jason (red helmet) had nearly caught a rather large rock I dislodged not long before hence being way in the back.



It was impressive looking from the top.



From here it just became a slog up the hill.







We even gave Jack a few moments to nap here and there.



Finally we were looking at the last push to the summit.



The top had nice views but was otherwise unremarkable. There were the remains of a wood cross that someone had tried to tie down sometime in the past and the usual register ammo box.



Jason toying with his new iPhone. Those damn iPhone users...





Before heading back down we took a moment for a group shot.



This was in the summit register. Sadly the website failed to exist so there goes my hopes for a zebu milk shake with liposuction debris and pesto.



Soon it was time to head down again. The general plan was to retrace our steps but instead of the 3rd class variation do the vanilla 2nd class DPS A route.





This worked fairly well except for one location where we cliffed out and had to backtrack slightly to get down the left side of the ridge without some sketchy down climbing.



The last little bit was even a rather pleasant slope we could skate down.



Anne with the ever fashionable forehead helmet imprint



It was a rather warm day and the wind had really sucked the moisture out of us. As a result several of our group were low or out of water. I had about $\frac{3}{4}$ of a liter left at that point which I gave out to others

The end result was I spent the last two hours or so of the hike without any liquid. As you can imagine I was quite happy when we reached the vehicles.

But not as happy as Anne.



The last 3 or 4 miles across the desert floor had been brutal and everyone was beat.





Slowly Gatorade, water, beer, and food resuscitated our group but no one was in a big hurry to relocate camp to Kingston so we decided to stay there. After all, Kingston was the easier peak according to the stats.



Other than the happy hour items Neal actually made some food which we all helped him get rid of.



We dug out a pit and had a small campfire though everyone was beat and turned in fairly early.



The following morning after a relatively longer period of sleep people were looking much better.



As a consequence of not moving camp the previous evening we now had to make the drive over to the Kingston trailhead.



The 19 miles of dirt road described in the DPS guide went quite quickly and after passing an active mine we soon arrived at our parking area.



I decided to leave my usual hat behind and go with my brand new WTC Snowmageddon 2011 cap that our group had made to commemorate our rather epic snow camp this year.



There was a 4wd road that could get us $\frac{3}{4}$ of a mile closer to the peak. We initially tried to drive it only to be turned back fairly quickly when the trucks started bottoming out.

Neal took this as a challenge and we devised a plan where he'd take most of the folks in his Tahoe and get as far down as he could while Jack and I hiked the road from the mine.





He soon reached a rather nasty spot he wouldn't pass either and everyone poured out.



Initially it was just some easy cross country dodging the occasional clump of brush.



Soon we entered the canyon we'd need to climb and the brush became significantly heavier.



This slowed us down a bit but we made steady progress and a few hours later climbed up on the ridge.



It was warm but after yesterdays rather stark lesson everyone was carrying extra water.



We could soon see the peak at the end of a rather long looking ridge.



Those wearing short sleeves like Anne were a bit marked up. It didn't come through well in the picture but it looked like she'd had a fight with several feral cats. I had on a long sleeve that now has several fresh rips in it.

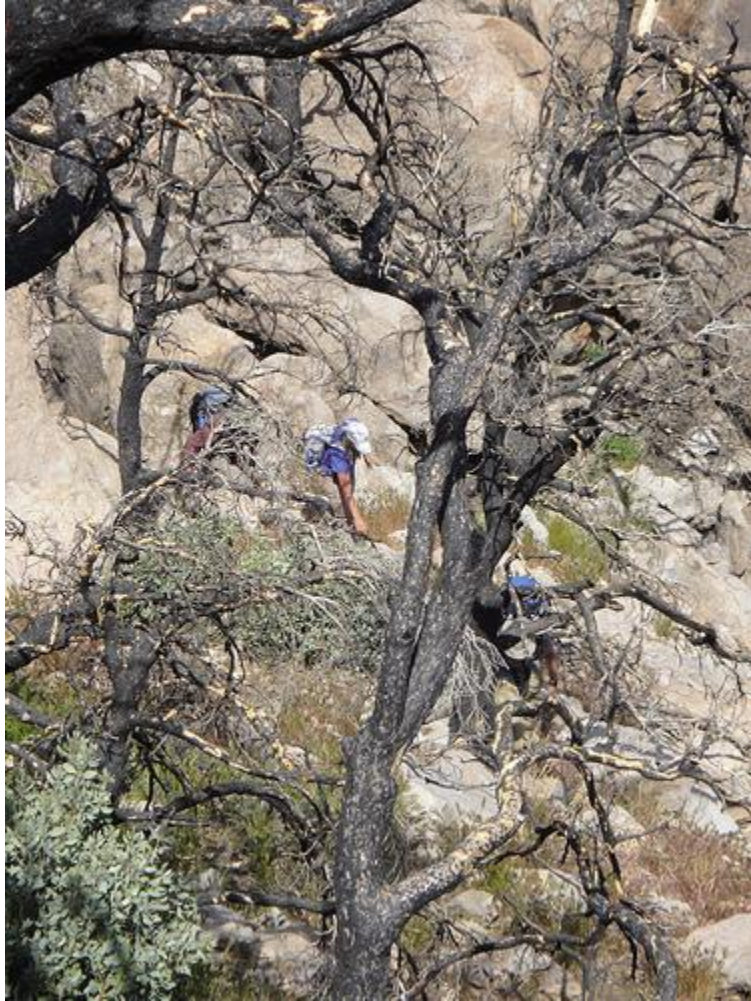




A ways down the ridge we did have a rather neat sighting of two bighorn sheep. One is on the top of the bump to the left and the second is climbing up the bump on the right.



The last bit up to the summit was through a mini forest of burned trees.



Soon we made it up top.

A rather tired Anne demonstrating how thankful she was I brought her on this little adventure...





We had a long hike out ahead of us so I threw out that I knew a decent Mexican food place in Baker (chips, salsa, and margaritas!) and we started down.



The ridge actually went much faster on the way back. The scattering of ducks we'd found on the way up seemed to be easier to follow this direction.





By the time we were looking back down the canyon it was getting towards sunset.



The bushwhack down was slow going. Part of the group took off ahead and made it to the car while it was still light out but those of us in the back got some use out of our headlamps.



And by the time we made the cars it was 9:30 pm. A long day.

But fortunately everyone was still in high spirits...



Well, assuming promising bodily harm to my person once she was able to walk again could be interpreted as high spirits...

Unfortunately by the time we made it into Baker it was around 11 pm. That meant the Mexican food place was long closed.

And so we ended up in Del Taco.



Party central!

Neal and Dave had taken off ahead, hit Carls Jr, and were already on the road home. Jason and Laurent napped in the parking lot for a bit and I loaded up on coffee to start the drive home.

Jack and I had planned to trade off but I was actually fine once I got some food and caffeine in me and Lisa was good enough to stay awake and chat with me for most of the drive.

We made it back to Jack's somewhere around 3 am and after dropping Anne off in Newport I was back home at 4:15 am. Ouch. That's the record so far this year by quite a good margin.

It just so happened I was on the 9 am flight out to Boise instead of the usual 6:45 am flight so I was actually able to get a short amount of sleep before heading for the airport.

Which left me horribly sleep deprived, only slightly sore, and with 5 days and counting until this year's Memorial Day Massacre 4 Day Peakbagging Extravaganza...